



Bio-inspired Adaptive Locomotion via Torque-based Learning

A Case Study of SATA

Safe and Adaptive Torque-Based Locomotion Policies Inspired by Animal Learning

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Main reference: *Li et al., SATA (RSS 2025)*

Command



Torque



Motion

1 Locomotion Is a Control Problem

THE PROBLEM

Position-based locomotion is accurate under known conditions but rigid — it struggles with compliance, disturbances, unknown terrain, and the sim-to-real gap.

RIGID CONTROL ON UNKNOWN TERRAIN



→ Torque control may improve compliance, providing conditions for more adaptive locomotion.

POSITION CONTROL

Command position

Rigid behavior

Poor adaptation

TORQUE CONTROL

Command force

Compliant interaction

Adaptive response

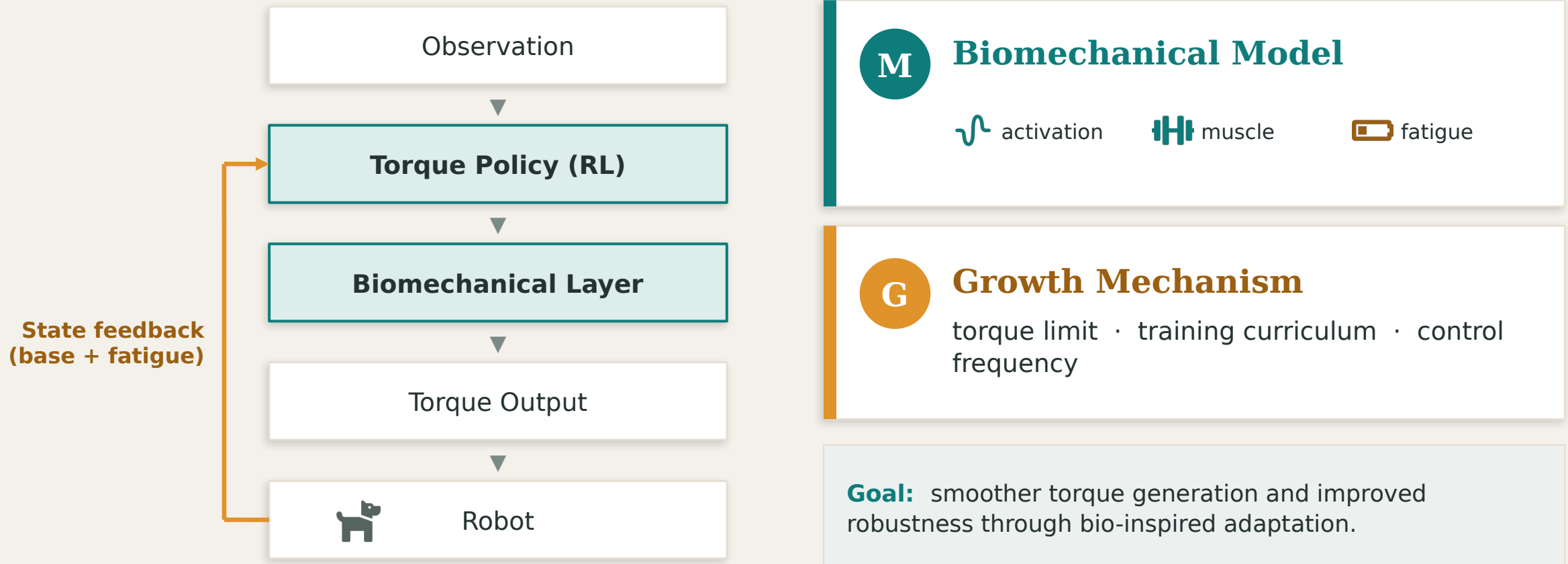
Adaptive behavior $\neq$ adaptive control

RESEARCH QUESTION

How can robots achieve safer and more adaptive locomotion in unknown environments?

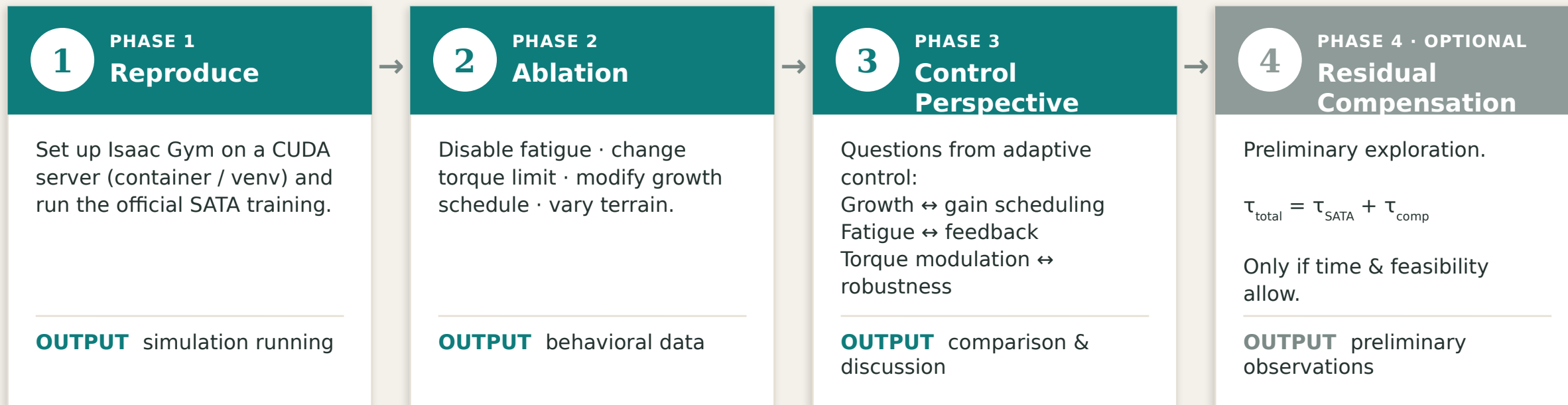
2 SATA Framework: Bio-inspired Adaptation in Torque Control

An RL torque policy wrapped by a biomechanical layer and a growth curriculum.



3 Plan: Understand → Reproduce → Analyze

A feasible 3-phase study, with an optional extension — we study SATA, not redesign the RL.



APPROACH

We analyze adaptation instead of proposing new methods — we do not redesign the RL algorithm.

4 Expected Outputs & Contribution

We study adaptive behavior — not propose a new RL algorithm.

EXPECTED OUTPUTS

- 1 Simulation reproduction
- 2 Behavior analysis (ablation)
- 3 Control-perspective comparison
- 4 Literature-grounded discussion

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

RQ1

Why torque control?

RQ2

What creates adaptation?

RQ3

How does SATA address problems traditionally studied in adaptive control?

RQ4

Can lightweight compensation help?

IN ONE LINE

This project studies how bio-inspired torque control produces adaptive locomotion, and asks how SATA answers questions traditionally posed by adaptive and robust control.